THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

“PHASE TWO”

July 13 – July 30, 2012
Los Feliz • San Diego

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

FADE IN:

INT. MARC-ANTHONY AND ESTHER'S HOUSE - NURSERY - LOS FELIZ - DAWN

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 13, 2012 - 5:10 A.M. PDT

A nursery painted in soft gold and red. Two cribs. A mobile of tiny felt planets turning slowly over each one. On the wall, a framed print of AVENGERS #1, and beside it, a framed playbill: HENRY V - NEW YORK SHAKESPEARE FESTIVAL - 1963.

ESTHER (29), nine weeks postpartum, sits in a rocking chair in a robe, feeding EMMA (9 weeks). MARC-ANTHONY (30) paces with VICTORIA (9 weeks), who is screaming at a volume that should not be physically possible for a ten-pound person.

MARC-ANTHONY
(bouncing her, singing badly)
"Iron Man, Iron Man, does whatever an iron can..."

ESTHER
That's the Spider-Man song.

MARC-ANTHONY
She doesn't know that.

Victoria screams louder.

ESTHER
She knows.

The bedroom door opens. CELESTE SMILLEY (52) walks in, already dressed, holding a cup of coffee. Right behind her, also already dressed, also holding a coffee: NATASHA BULLOCK (51). The two grandmothers have been staying in the guest rooms all week, by agreement, in shifts that quietly turned into the same shift.

CELESTE
Give me the Thunderer.

NATASHA
I'll take Emma when she's done.

MARC-ANTHONY
(handing over Victoria, relieved)
She hates my singing.

CELESTE
(instantly rocking her, and Victoria instantly stops crying)
Everybody hates your singing, baby. Go pack. You have a flight to San Diego.

Marc-Anthony looks at Esther.

MARC-ANTHONY
You sure you're coming? Dr. Patel said...

ESTHER
Dr. Patel said I can fly to San Diego, walk across a stage, wave, and come home Saturday night. Kevin says Hall H has been asking about Thor for a year. I'm not missing it.

NATASHA
(dryly)
And we'll be fine. Two grandmothers. Two babies. What could go wrong?

Celeste and Natasha look at each other over the babies' heads. A year ago they had never been in the same room. Now they share a coffee maker.

CELESTE
Natasha folds onesies wrong.

NATASHA
Celeste uses too much powder.

CELESTE
There's no such thing as too much powder.

NATASHA
Your granddaughter looks like a sugar donut.

Esther and Marc-Anthony exchange a look, trying very hard not to laugh.

CUT TO:

EXT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - HALL H LINE - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 13, 2012 - 11:20 P.M. PDT

The sixth annual reunion of "THE WORTHY." The canopy is now a professional pop-up tent with a printed banner and LED lights. Fans line up to take photos with them; they've become semi-famous on Superhero Hype.

GARY MORRIS (46), PRIYA SHAH (27), DARNELL JOHNSON (34), TOMMY REYES (24). Priya's T-shirt has a new line printed under her username: "DR. NoNerfsPlz (PhD, Caltech, May 2012)."

TOMMY
Phase Two. Kevin's been saying it in interviews for months. "Phase Two." Tomorrow he's going to tell us what it is.

GARY
Iron Man 3, obviously. Thor 2. Cap 2. Avengers 2. Easy.

DARNELL
The titles, though. Watch the titles. Marvel never names anything by accident.

PRIYA
And the cosmic stuff. Thanos was in the post-credits scene. Mistress Death. The Gauntlet. You don't show the Gauntlet unless you're going to space.

TOMMY
Space like what?

PRIYA
Space like the Guardians of the Galaxy. The 2008 Abnett and Lanning team. A raccoon with a gun and a tree that says one sentence.

Long pause.

GARY
Priya, they are not making a movie about a raccoon with a gun.

PRIYA
Gary. They made a movie about a guy who talks to ants, and it made two hundred million dollars.

GARY
(a long, defeated sigh)
...I'm pre-writing apology #214.

CUT TO:

INT. SAN DIEGO MARRIOTT MARQUIS - MARVEL GREEN ROOM - DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 14, 2012 - 10:45 A.M. PDT

The Marvel suite. It's three times the size of 2007's now: catering, a full press staff, a security detail. The cast of Phase Two mingle: MARC-ANTHONY, ESTHER, TYRESE AVERY (30), TYLER CHAPMAN (30), DAVID TIPTON (31), ELXA BULLOCK (31), TOM HIDDLESTON (31), and directors SHANE BLACK (50), ANTHONY RUSSO (42) and JOE RUSSO (40), EDGAR WRIGHT (38).

KEVIN FEIGE (39) stands at the head of the room with a laptop, LENORA HAYES (47) beside him.

FEIGE
Today we announce Phase Two. Six films. Iron Man 3, May 2013. Thor 2, November 2013. Cap 2, April 2014. Guardians of the Galaxy, August 2014. Avengers 2, May 2015. Ant-Man 2, July 2015. And today, for the first time, three of them get real titles.

He clicks. On the laptop: "THOR: THE DARK WORLD." A murmur. Esther smiles.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
Malekith. The Dark Elves. Walt Simonson's best run. And Thor fighting for both of her worlds.

Click. "CAPTAIN AMERICA: THE WINTER SOLDIER."

The room goes silent. Tyler Chapman, standing beside Tyrese, slowly sets down his coffee.

TYLER
(very quietly)
...Winter Soldier.

JOE RUSSO
Ed Brubaker. 2005. You're about to have the best two years of your life, Tyler.

TYLER
Bucky's alive.

ANTHONY RUSSO
Bucky's alive. And he doesn't remember a single thing. And Steve has to decide whether to save his best friend or stop him.

Tyrese puts a hand on Tyler's shoulder. Tyler looks like he might cry.

TYLER (CONT'D)
When I was cast, I thought I died in the first movie.

TYRESE
You did die in the first movie, man. Now you get to come back.

Lenora clears her throat.

LENORA
And the rules. No spoilers about Bucky. No spoilers about the Mandarin. No spoilers about anything to do with Ultron, which isn't in Phase Two as far as anyone knows.

DAVID
(half raising his hand)
Lenora, I literally don't know anything about Ultron.

LENORA
Good. Keep it that way, Hank.

David exchanges a look with Edgar Wright. Something passes between them: David does know something. Edgar shakes his head slightly. Not here.

Amond pokes his head in the door, here as Harmony's plus-one again. (She's at home in New York this time; he came anyway.)

AMOND
Am I allowed on stage?

FEIGE, LENORA, AND WHEDON (O.S.)
(in unison)
No.

AMOND
That's fair.

CUT TO:

INT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - HALL H - DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 14, 2012 - 1:00 P.M. PDT

Six thousand five hundred people. The room has never been louder. On the giant screens, the AVENGERS logo spins. A scroll beneath it: "$1,503,000,000 WORLDWIDE."

Feige walks out. The ovation lasts a full minute. Somebody starts the chant, and it's older now, part of the room: "NO-BO-DY! NO-BO-DY!"

FEIGE
(holding up his hands, grinning)
Six years ago, I stood on this stage and told you nobody would get nerfed.

(pointing at the screen)
One point five billion dollars later... thank you. From all of us. Thank you.

Another standing ovation.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
And now... Phase Two.

The lights drop. A logo slams onto the screens: "MARVEL STUDIOS - PHASE TWO."

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - IRON MAN 3 - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 14, 2012 - 1:08 P.M. PDT

IRON MAN 3 - MAY 3, 2013. Footage: Tony Stark's Malibu mansion, the real house built on the real cliffs, blown apart by real helicopter gunships. Tony dragged under the Pacific in the Mark XLII armor. A voice on a television broadcast, calm, cultured, terrifying:

BEN KINGSLEY (ON SCREEN, AS THE MANDARIN)
Mr. Stark. Ten rings. Ten powers. And I have spent a thousand years learning to use every one of them.

The camera finds his hands: ten rings, each glowing a different color.

Hall H GASPS. The real Mandarin. Comic-accurate. Rings and all.

Then: Tony, alone in a dark workshop, staring at a glass of whiskey. His hands shaking. A voice-over from Pepper:

TAYIA (ON SCREEN, AS PEPPER)
You can't build a suit for this one, Tony.

The footage ends. Shane Black and Marc-Anthony walk out to a roar.

SHANE BLACK
Iron Man 3 is two stories from the comics. Warren Ellis's EXTREMIS. And DEMON IN A BOTTLE, from 1979. Tony Stark at war with the Mandarin, and at war with himself.

A wave of awe through the hall. The fans know what "Demon in a Bottle" is.

MARC-ANTHONY
(into the mic, sincere for once)
It's the hardest thing I've ever done. Tony at the bottom. I didn't want to play him like it was a joke. A lot of people have a bottle in their lives. This is for them.

A moment of real silence. Then warm, respectful applause.

FAN (O.S.)
(from the back) TONY STARK DOESN'T NEED A SUIT!

MARC-ANTHONY
(grinning, breaking the mood)
That's exactly what my mom said when I asked for a Mark XLIII.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - THOR: THE DARK WORLD - LATER

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 14, 2012 - 1:25 P.M. PDT

The screens: "THOR: THE DARK WORLD - NOVEMBER 8, 2013." No footage. Filming hasn't started. Just a single image: Mjolnir, lying on cracked black stone under a dark red sky. A crowd of Dark Elves silhouetted on the horizon.

FEIGE
We haven't shot a frame yet. We start in September in Iceland and Norway. But I thought you might want to say hello to someone.

The crowd starts chanting before he can say the name: "THOR! THOR! THOR!"

ESTHER SMILLEY (29) walks out. No cape this time. A simple white dress. Nine weeks after giving birth to twins. The hall goes absolutely insane.

She walks to the microphone, overwhelmed by the noise. She puts her hand over her heart. Waits. The roar finally settles.

ESTHER
Hi.

(beat)
I can't stay long. I have two very loud people at home who don't care that I'm Thor.

Laughter and applause.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
I just wanted to say thank you. Last year I told you I could breathe. This year...

(her voice catching)
This year I'm a mother. And I'm Thor. And I'm going to go to Iceland in September and swing that hammer at a whole army of Dark Elves, because I want my daughters to grow up knowing their mother can do both.

The hall erupts. A wall of sound. "SHE IS WORTHY! SHE IS WORTHY!" Priya, in the third row, is weeping openly. Darnell has his arm around her.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
(smiling, wiping her eyes)
Okay. I have to go pump. Thank you, San Diego!

She leaves the stage to a standing ovation. Backstage, she walks straight into Marc-Anthony's arms.

MARC-ANTHONY
"I have to go pump." In Hall H.

ESTHER
It's true. I do.

MARC-ANTHONY
It's the most Thor thing you've ever said.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - CAPTAIN AMERICA: THE WINTER SOLDIER - LATER

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 14, 2012 - 1:40 P.M. PDT

The lights drop. On screen, in slow, cold letters: "CAPTAIN AMERICA: THE WINTER SOLDIER." Below: "APRIL 4, 2014."

Silence for one second. Then a sound unlike anything else that day, not a cheer but a collective GASP, followed by six thousand people turning to each other at once.

In the third row, Darnell has both hands on his head.

DARNELL
THE WINTER SOLDIER. BRUBAKER. 2005. BUCKY'S ALIVE. BUCKY IS ALIVE!

TOMMY
Wait. Wait. Is that a spoiler? Did they just spoil their own movie in the title?

PRIYA
Tommy, the title IS the spoiler. They don't care. They want us to know. They want us to sit in the theater for two years waiting for Steve to see his face.

Tyrese and Tyler walk out together with the RUSSO BROTHERS. Tyrese is carrying Cap's shield. Tyler is wearing a black leather jacket and a single glove over his left hand. He holds up the gloved hand. Underneath it, a glint of silver metal.

The crowd SCREAMS.

ANTHONY RUSSO
We wanted to make a 1970s political thriller. THREE DAYS OF THE CONDOR, with a shield.

JOE RUSSO
And every punch you'll see, these two actually threw. Real fights. No doubles. Tyler's been training with the arm for four months.

TYLER
(into the mic, emotional)
In 2010 I was told I'd play Bucky and die on a train. I thought that was my whole story. Ed Brubaker brought Bucky back in 2005, and Marvel just brought me back too.

(holding up the silver arm)
I hope I can make him as broken and as brave as Ed did.

Tyrese throws an arm around him.

TYRESE
He's my best friend in this movie and in real life. And I'm going to have to fight him. And it's going to hurt.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY / ANT-MAN / AVENGERS - LATER

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 14, 2012 - 2:00 P.M. PDT

Feige alone on the stage again.

FEIGE
Four more. Very quickly. Because I can see Lenora backstage looking at her watch.

Laughter. The screen: "GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY - AUGUST 1, 2014." A single piece of concept art: five silhouettes against a nebula. A man in a long red coat with a mask. A green-skinned woman with a sword. A hulking gray man covered in red tattoos. A tree-like giant. And, at the front, holding a gun twice his size: a raccoon.

The hall erupts in a mix of cheers and bewildered laughter.

In the third row, Priya grabs Gary by the collar.

PRIYA
A RACCOON WITH A GUN, GARY.

GARY
(defeated)
A raccoon with a gun.

FEIGE
And yes, if you remember a certain purple gentleman from a certain post-credits scene... space is where he lives.

Massive cheers. The screen: "ANT-MAN - JULY 31, 2015." The logo, then a short test reel: Edgar Wright's camera following the Ant-Man suit as it shrinks, runs across a turntable in a nightclub, rides a bullet in mid-air, and lands

on the head of a security guard. But the man in the suit is moving differently than Hank Pym. Faster. Clumsier. Funnier.

Then the helmet comes off, out of focus, the face blurred. A voice:

UNKNOWN VOICE (ON SCREEN)
...So, uh, Dr. Pym? Your suit. I think I broke it. A little.

Black. Edgar Wright and David Tipton walk out to a roar.

EDGAR WRIGHT
That's all you get.

FAN (O.S.)
WHO'S IN THE SUIT?

DAVID
(into the mic, carefully)
Hank Pym's story isn't over. But in the comics, Hank is a lot of people. Ant-Man. Giant-Man. Goliath. Yellowjacket.

(beat)
And in 1979, somebody else put on his helmet.

The hall erupts. Tommy, in the third row, stands up on his chair.

TOMMY
SCOTT LANG! MARVEL PREMIERE #47! HE STEALS THE SUIT TO SAVE HIS DAUGHTER!

PRIYA
(pulling him down)
TOMMY, SIT DOWN!

TOMMY
THERE'S GONNA BE TWO ANT-MEN!

Feige raises his hand. The final title card. Simple. White letters.

"THE AVENGERS 2 - MAY 1, 2015."

FEIGE
Joss Whedon is back. That's all I'm saying today.

FAN (O.S.)
(from the front rows, a familiar voice)
Read Avengers #16?

Feige laughs. He finds Priya in the crowd and points at her.

FEIGE
You know, I'm going to retire that line, Priya.

(beat, a twinkle)
Try Avengers #54.

Silence. The comic nerds in the room are doing math. Then, slowly, a ripple through the hall. Gasps.

TOMMY
(whispering)
What's in #54?

PRIYA
(white as a sheet)
Ultron.

DARNELL
Hank Pym builds Ultron. In the comics. Hank built him.

TOMMY
(very slowly turning to look at the stage, at David Tipton)
...oh, no.

On stage, David Tipton stares at the floor. Then he looks up and gives the crowd a small, sad smile.

CUT TO:

MONTAGE - PHASE TWO HITS THE INTERNET

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 14 - SUNDAY, JULY 15, 2012

REDDIT.COM - r/marvelstudios - "PHASE TWO ANNOUNCED - MEGATHREAD" - 52,118 comments

u/hulk_doesnt_read (2:15 PM)
THE WINTER SOLDIER. BUCKY IS ALIVE. THE TITLE IS THE SPOILER AND I DON'T CARE.

u/MadTitanFan (2:20 PM)
GUARDIANS. Space. Thanos lives in space. Feige basically said it. Infinity Gauntlet is coming through the Guardians.

u/GemCollector (2:31 PM)
"Try Avengers #54." That's ULTRON. And Ultron's creator in the comics is HANK PYM. Is David Tipton's Hank going to build Ultron in Avengers 2?? And then a NEW Ant-Man takes over two months later in Ant-Man 2? That's... devastating. And comic-accurate.

u/ShellHead1963 (2:45 PM)
The REAL Mandarin. Ten rings. Ben Kingsley. Demon in a Bottle. Apology #214, which I wrote last night about the raccoon. Now I need #215 for the Mandarin.

u/NoNerfsPlz (2:50 PM)
I've been asking Kevin questions for six years. Today he told me to retire my line. Then he gave me a new one. "Try Avengers #54." I'm going to frame the video.

u/raccoon_skeptic (3:10 PM)
a raccoon with a gun. marvel is either about to have its first flop or invent a new kind of movie star. no in between.

YOUTUBE.COM - "ESTHER SMILLEY 'I HAVE TO GO PUMP' - HALL H 2012" - 8,402,117 views in 3 days

Top comment - workingmom_lisa: a postpartum mother walked on stage in front of 6500 screaming people, said she was going to fight an army of elves in September, and then left to pump. i have never felt so seen

TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - SATURDAY, JULY 14, 2012

#PhaseTwo - #WinterSoldier - Bucky Is Alive - The Mandarin - Rocket Raccoon - Avengers #54 - I Have To Go Pump

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

tylerchapman: bucky's alive. i'm alive. thank you hall h. thank you ed brubaker. thank you @tyreseavery for not letting me cry on stage. (i cried backstage) 3:15 PM Jul 14th from Twitter for iPhone

davidtipton: i know nothing about avengers #54. i have never heard of avengers #54. please stop sending me avengers #54. 4:02 PM Jul 14th from Twitter for iPhone

amondbaker: they didn't let me on stage this year. i sat in the green room and ate 9 bagels. phase two looks incredible. i know NOTHING. for once that's true. 4:30 PM Jul 14th from Twitter for iPhone

esthersmilley: back home with my girls. victoria screamed for 40 minutes because i was gone. emma just looked disappointed. both are correct. thank you hall h 9:45 PM Jul 14th from Twitter for iPhone

CUT TO:

INT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - BACKSTAGE CORRIDOR - DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 14, 2012 - 2:30 P.M. PDT

The same concrete corridor where Desmond threatened Marc-Anthony two years ago. Marc-Anthony is walking Esther toward the exit, where a car is waiting to take her to the airport.

At the end of the corridor, by the exit door, stands DESMOND SMILLEY (54). Esther's manager. Still. In a cream suit. Holding a diaper bag.

Esther stops. Marc-Anthony stops.

ESTHER
Daddy? You came?

DESMOND
I'm your manager. You had a public appearance. Managers go to public appearances.

(holding up the diaper bag, awkward)
Your mother said you'd forget the breast pump. You forgot the breast pump.

Esther laughs out loud and takes the bag.

ESTHER
I did forget it.

DESMOND
You always forgot your lunch, too. Every day for six years. I drove it to the studio lot.

A pause. Desmond looks at Marc-Anthony. Two years ago, in this same corridor, he said "Stay away from my daughter." Marc-Anthony remembers. So does Desmond.

DESMOND (CONT'D)
(stiffly)
Mr. Bullock.

MARC-ANTHONY
Mr. Smilley.

DESMOND
Victoria spit up on my best suit on Wednesday.

MARC-ANTHONY
She does that.

DESMOND
It was a nine-hundred-dollar suit.

MARC-ANTHONY
She has expensive taste. She gets that from you.

A long pause. Then, very slightly, the corner of Desmond's mouth twitches. Almost a smile.

DESMOND
...She does.

He turns and holds the exit door open for his daughter. Esther looks back at Marc-Anthony.

ESTHER
I'll see you tonight.

MARC-ANTHONY
I'll be home by eleven. I just have the press room.

She goes. Desmond hesitates in the doorway. Then, without looking back:

DESMOND
She was good up there. On the stage. She's always been good.

MARC-ANTHONY
She's the best I've ever seen, sir.

Desmond nods once and lets the door close behind him.

CUT TO:

EXT. MARC-ANTHONY AND ESTHER'S HOUSE - BACK PORCH - LOS FELIZ - NIGHT

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 14, 2012 - 11:45 P.M. PDT

Marc-Anthony comes up the back steps in the dark. He stops. Esther is sitting on the porch swing in a robe, a baby monitor beside her, both twins asleep inside. On the porch rail sits a single yellow No. 2 pencil.

ESTHER
It's eleven forty-five.

MARC-ANTHONY
I know. I'm late. The press room...

ESTHER
No. It's eleven forty-five. On Comic-Con Saturday.

(beat)
The stairwell. Every year.

Marc-Anthony goes very still. He looks at the pencil on the rail. He reaches into the inside pocket of his jacket. His hand is shaking.

MARC-ANTHONY
Esther. I was going to do this in the stairwell. At the Marriott. I had it all planned. The security guard was in on it. Gerald. He was going to hold the door.

ESTHER
I know. Gerald called me at nine to ask why you weren't there yet. I told him you were coming home. To us.

Marc-Anthony laughs, a breathless, overwhelmed laugh. He takes a small velvet box out of his pocket. He gets down on one knee on the porch.

MARC-ANTHONY
Esther Smilley. You told me you wanted to do this right. Not because of a pregnancy test. Not because of the cameras. Not because anybody expected it.

(beat)
So I waited until nobody expected it. Until our girls were here. Until your father held one of them. Until our grandfathers were friends again.

(opening the box: a simple, perfect diamond on a gold band, and engraved inside it, two tiny words)
It says "since 1994." Because I've been yours since you stole my pencil.

(his voice cracking)
Will you marry me?

Esther looks at the ring. At the man on one knee on her porch at midnight. At the baby monitor glowing beside her.

ESTHER
(crying, laughing)
You didn't steal my pencil. I stole YOURS.

MARC-ANTHONY
That's a yes?

ESTHER
That's a yes. Out loud.

(beat)
Very, very out loud.

He slides the ring onto her finger. She pulls him up and kisses him on the porch swing.

And from the baby monitor, as if on cue, a single furious scream. Victoria.

MARC-ANTHONY
(laughing against her lips)
She heard.

ESTHER
She's a Smilley. She has opinions about everything.

Marc-Anthony gets up. He kisses Esther again, then heads inside toward the nursery.

MARC-ANTHONY (O.S.)
(from inside) Coming, Thunderer! Daddy's coming! Daddy's getting MARRIED!

Esther sits on the swing, looking at the ring on her finger, at the pencil on the porch rail, at the city lights below. She picks up her phone. Dials. It rings once.

CELESTE (V.O.)
(sleepy)
Baby? It's midnight. Are the girls okay?

ESTHER
(smiling, crying)
Mama. He asked.

A sharp gasp on the other end of the line. Then, faintly, in the background, a man's voice, Desmond's:

DESMOND (V.O.)
(muffled, half asleep)
...Who's on the phone?

CELESTE (V.O.)
(muffled, hand over the receiver)
It's Esther. The Bullock boy proposed.

A long pause on the line. Esther holds her breath.

DESMOND (V.O.)
(muffled, far away, but clear)
...Tell her it's about time.

Esther covers her mouth with her hand.

FADE OUT.

HEADLINES

SUPER: MONDAY, JULY 16, 2012

VARIETY - MON JULY 16, 2012

MARVEL UNVEILS PHASE TWO: 'IRON MAN 3,' 'THE DARK WORLD,' 'WINTER SOLDIER,' 'GUARDIANS,' 'ANT-MAN,' 'AVENGERS 2'

Feige's six-film slate runs through July 2015; the real Mandarin, Brubaker's Bucky and a raccoon with a gun headline Hall H's biggest day. A cryptic "Avengers #54" tease sends fans scrambling.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - MON JULY 16, 2012

"PHASE TWO": MARVEL'S PLAN IS NOW A BLUEPRINT FOR HOLLYWOOD

Rival studios have begun announcing "shared universes" of their own. "The difference is Marvel built theirs on the actual comics," says one agent. "Everybody else is building on IP spreadsheets."

PEOPLE.COM - EXCLUSIVE - MONDAY, JULY 16, 2012

MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK AND ESTHER SMILLEY ARE ENGAGED!

"He proposed on our porch at 11:45 p.m. on Comic-Con Saturday. It's a long story involving a pencil from 1994 and a security guard named Gerald. We'll tell you the whole thing someday." The couple, parents of 9-week-old twins Emma and Victoria, are planning a 2013 wedding.

TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - MONDAY, JULY 16, 2012

#StarkThorEngaged - Since 1994 - Gerald - Pencil - #PhaseTwo

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

SDMarriottGerald: I'm the security guard. Every year since 2009 I caught him in that stairwell at midnight. This year I was supposed to hold the door. He went home to her instead. Best decision he ever made. Congratulations, Mr. Stark. 11:02 AM Jul 16th from Twitter for Android

amondbaker: I KNEW ABOUT THE RING FOR SIX WEEKS AND DIDN'T TELL ANYONE. NOT EVEN HARMONY. this time it's actually true. I AM A NEW MAN 11:30 AM Jul 16th from Twitter for iPhone

harmonydivine: @amondbaker it's true. he really didn't tell me. i'm a little proud and a little concerned 11:34 AM Jul 16th from Twitter for iPhone

JET MAGAZINE - COVER (Issue of July 30, 2012)

SHE SAID YES

Iron Man and Thor are engaged. Two grandmothers share a nursery. Two great-grandfathers share a scotch. And a View Park father says "it's about time." Inside the most romantic summer in Hollywood history.

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER SIXTEEN